

Now that the Nehru-Gandhi family is miffed with Singh's remark that the Congress was functioning more democratically under Indira Gandhi, he will find it hard to re-establish himself as an obedient servant of the dynasty. He should try being loyal to the country instead.

A. Srikanthiah, *Bangalore*

Politics of Vendetta

Barely a month after coming to power, the coalition Government in Pakistan is falling apart on the issue of reinstatement of judges, including former chief justice Mohammad Iftikhar Chaudhry ("Heading For Divorce", May 26). While PML-N chief Nawaz Sharif is keen on settling scores with Musharraf, who had overthrown him in 1998, PPP's acting President Asif Zardari is diffident as he seems to have committed to the Americans that he will not be party to the 'loyal' Musharraf's ouster. Only a miracle can hoist a stable government into power in Pakistan now.

R.J. KHURANA, *Bhopal*

Simply the Best

That Chetan Bhagat is now a firmly established name in Indian writing in English is something no one can deny ("The Power of Three", May 26). But more importantly, he is also the one who introduced light reading to modern Indians. Bhagat, who is able to feel the pulse of today's generation, helps them face real problems.

Readability, that first requirement of good writing, has found a talented exponent in him.

AMITABH THAKUR, *Lucknow*

Tricky Business

Vijay Mallya's anger following the poor performance of the Royal Challengers in IPL is understandable ("Corporate Crackdown", May 26). Mallya sank a fortune in the tournament. He should have realised, however, that his team was full of older players who are better suited for Test cricket. A shrewd businessman, Mallya has been taken for a ride this time.

K. VENKATARAMAN, *Mumbai*

Wary of Wealth

Anyone who believes super-rich politicians will do good for the *aam aadmi* lives in a fool's paradise ("The Cash Clout", May 19). Once elected, they will misuse their power to evade tax, convert black money and indulge in favouritism. With rich lobbies in Karnataka scrambling for power, democracy is tapering off.

SUNEJ VASUDEVAN, *Secunderabad*

DIVIDE AND MISRULE



Raj Thackeray is following the same beaten path his uncle Bal Thackeray walked ("Playing Catch-up", May 26). In the name of Marathi chauvinism, he is provoking frustrated youth against north Indians.

A. SRIKANTIAH, *Bangalore*

Divisive politics is on the rise. Recently, in a school in the Sanghur district of Punjab, the turban was made compulsory for non-sikh students, creating friction between communities.

MAYA AGARWAL, *Kanpur*

Despite frequent outbursts by Raj against north Indians, the Congress and NCP are mum on the issue, obviously with an eye on the elections due in 2009. They are more interested in dividing the vote base of Shiv Sena-BJP. The whole episode is eroding Mumbai's peaceful, cosmopolitan culture.

K.R. SRINIVASAN, *Chennai*

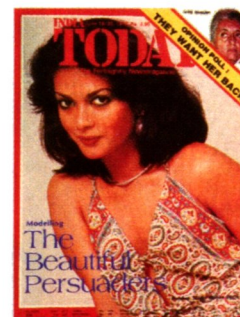
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Years Ago in India Today

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Easy Come, Easy Go

They are a race apart. Long tapering legs fitted tightly in jeans; firm busty torsos swathed in summer-cool sheaths; feet precariously encased in stiletto heels; hair carefully tousled and lips sultry-wet, they toot around town with the panache of professional predators. These are the girls who tout a thousand products, who sit beneath waterfalls and slither into sunsets, who transform sweaty armpits into fragrant champits. "I'm not in it for the bread. But you can make it



Dutta

fast, then clear out fast," says Monica Dutta, a 19-year-old raven-haired, bedroom-eyed beauty, whom the advertising agency-wallahs currently find irresistible. In 1976, advertising expenditure in India was estimated at Rs 115 crore. A year later, it had risen by a neat Rs 10 crore. Says a 22-year-old model, "While it lasts, it's good living, it's real gas. But actually, it's the biggest rip-off of all time."

—Sunil Sethi, *Mandira Purie*